Hassan Ali Joho

(JO-ho)

Cabinet Secretary for Mining, Blue Ocean Economy, and Maritime Affairs
Republic of Kenya

Addressed as: **Your Excellency** | Office held since: **July 2024**

Cabinet Secretary Joho is a charismatic leader who views his position as an opportunity to grow Kenya's economy and expand his political influence.

- **Projecting a Common Touch**
  Joho presents himself as a man of the people, hyping policies and programs, including his charitable foundation, that respond to community needs. He has called himself the “CS [Cabinet Secretary] Who Listens.”

- **Pledging an Economic Windfall**
  Since his appointment as cabinet secretary, Joho has been insistent about the country’s economic potential in sectors “rich with opportunities.”

One of Joho’s talents is turning a negative into a positive. His nickname “sultan” was initially given to him by an opponent to cast him as a tyrant, but he embraced it as an affirmation of his authority and largesse.

WHY THEY MATTER

As steward of the country's vast mineral and maritime resources, Joho is relying on populism and policy reforms to advance Kenyan priorities.

- **Curbing Exploitative Practices**
  Joho has promised to crack down on illegal mining and foreign entities that "have been extracting our minerals for over ten years without compensating the communities." He has unveiled a specialized investigative arm under the Mining Police Unit to address this issue.

- **Contributing to Kenyan Prosperity**
  Joho talks up about the potential of his portfolio to increase mining's contributions to Kenya's GDP and deliver "better schools, healthcare, and jobs."

While the mining sector is a top priority, Joho's personal and political connection to the Kenyan coast may result in a greater focus on and receptivity to initiatives related to the blue economy and maritime affairs.

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MEETING WITH THEM

Joho maintains a relaxed and informal style, disarming his interlocutors with his openness and political dexterity.

- **Sharing Personal Stories**
  Joho peppers his conversations with his own personal narrative, often to underscore key points. He has cited his own humble upbringing or his closeness to his mother ("my best friend") to show his depth of character and vulnerability.

- **Reframing Criticisms**
  While the Cabinet Secretary defends his decisions and political allegiances, he downplays setbacks and critiques. He has turned his record of poor performance as a "D minus" student into a parable of struggle and self-improvement."

Due to his poor academic record and other controversies related to his educational qualifications, Joho is eager to present himself as a learned man; he has boasted about his coursework at the Harvard Kennedy School of Government and pride in one day being called "Dr. Hassan Joho, His Excellency."

ON THEIR MIND

- **Critical Minerals Ministerial**
  U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio welcomed "partners from across the globe" for the inaugural Critical Minerals Ministerial on 4 February, including senior officials from the Democratic Republic of Congo, Kenya and Guinea.

- **Political Party Disputes**
  Since the death of political leader Raila Odinga, there has been a rift over control of the Orange Democratic Movement (ODM), pitting Odinga's 82-year-old brother against the party's younger leaders.

- **Legal Battle Over Mombasa Port**
  Joho's family is battling billionaire Mohammed Jaffer over control of Mombasa port logistics business, alleging that Jaffer orchestrated a smear campaign to defame Joho's brother Abubakar Ali.

- **Kenyan GDP growth**
  Kenya's economy grew by 4.9 percent year-on-year in the third quarter of 2025, from 4.2 percent in the same quarter the previous year. Kenya National Bureau of Statistics said the growth mainly came from the agriculture sector and the construction industry.

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NETWORK

Joho is conspicuous about his extensive international network, flaunting his ties to U.S. and other foreign officials and business leaders in flashy social media posts.

Joho views the United States as a key partner, but he is open to work with everyone. In the past year, he met with U.S. Deputy Secretary of State Christopher Landau and Senator Sheldon Whitehouse of Rhode Island. He also hosted a Ukrainian delegation, engaged the Moroccan Minister of Energy Transition and Sustainable Development, and participated in global events in London and Perth.

Since Odinga's death in October 2025, Joho has positioned himself as a loyalist to both his late mentor's legacy and to President Ruto's broad-based government.

At Odinga's funeral, Joho declared: "I was taken to the government of William Ruto by Raila Odinga, and that is where I belong and where I will stay." In his public tribute, he called Odinga "my compass" and credited him with shaping his political values. Joho's stance has placed him in the pro-government faction of a fractured ODM, opposing party members who want to field a presidential candidate in 2027.

CONTROVERSIES

Joho's career has been plagued by criminal and corruption allegations, as well as criticisms directed at his academic pedigree and ostentatious lifestyle.

- **Drug Trafficking and Graft Allegations**
  Joho has been accused of linkages to a drug cartel and economic crimes, including bribery and irregular procurement practices during his time as Mombasa County governor. Joho has denied these allegations, pointing to his continued ability to travel internationally as evidence of his innocence.

- **Forged Education Certificates**
  In 2017, Kenyan police investigated allegations that he forged his Kenya Certificate of Secondary Education, a charge that would disqualify him from holding public office if proven true. Almost a decade later, this accusation continues to resurface as he reaches for higher political office.

Joho's penchant for luxury fashion and extravagant living is a staple of media outlets and his social media. He takes selfies with Paris Hilton, houses giraffes on his estate, and has been seen wearing an expensive white Moncler Dincer jacket and Alexander McQueen sneakers.

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CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- **Cabinet Secretary for Mining, Blue Economy, and Maritime Affairs**, Government of Kenya (2024 to present)
- **Governor**, Mombasa County (2013-2022)
- **Member of Parliament**, Kisauni Constituency (2007-2013)
- **Party Chairman**, Liberal Democratic Party, Kisauni Branch (2005-2007)
- **Managing Director,** Prima Pest and Bins Limited (1997-2005)

BIO

Joho's rags to riches story is central to his image, winning him admirers and detractors in equal measure. Born on February 26, 1976, in Kisauni, Mombasa, Joho often credits the coastal way of life for shaping his sense of community and his inclusive approach to politics.

- **Starting as a Garbage Collector**
  Joho made his fortune in waste management, as well as shipping and logistics, before entering politics. He earned a Bachelor's degree in Business and Human Resource Management from Kampala University, and has taken courses at Harvard Kennedy School of Government.

- **Plugging his Active Lifestyle=**
  Joho, who favors vibrant shirts and caps, even at official events, loves to show off his workout regimens, sparring with his boxing coach, and taking laps in his swimming pool. He is also an avid golfer and huge soccer fan, especially of Arsenal FC.

Joho is married with several children. He was raised in a Muslim household, and continues to cite Islam as the "foundation of everything I do." The Cabinet Secretary speaks English and Swahili.

NOTES